

By that point, Naomi had gone back to school. Since Ben took care of paying the bills, she hadn't realized they were behind. When she found out, she was devastated. Ben's dad demanded that they pay the past-due bill. When Ben told him they couldn't, his dad suggested that Naomi get a fulltime job.

"Ben, I can't see any way that we can keep this house," Naomi said. "Maybe we should try to sell it. I really don't want to have to drop out of school now."

"We won't have to sell the house," Ben replied emphatically. "I can get a loan on the car to catch up the payments. I'm due for a raise pretty soon; then we'll have enough to make it."

"What if the raise doesn't come through?" Naomi asked.

"You don't need to worry. Trust me; everything's going to work out."

So Naomi put the subject of finances out of her mind. But she couldn't shake the nagging feeling of impending disaster.

Ben negotiated a loan on his car for enough to catch up the credit union payment with some left over. He used that to buy a Blu-Ray disc player, reasoning they could have home entertainment instead of going out.

When Ben received his next check with the loan payment taken out, he was shocked. His net pay for the first pay period of the month was far less than he was counting on. He had already mailed the house payment, anticipating his pay, and he realized that the check probably wouldn't clear. Sure enough, the bank alerted him by e-mail and also mailed a statement that the check to the mortgage company had been paid, but their checking account was being charged for insufficient funds. Ben and Naomi were appalled at the daily fee for being in the red.

Not knowing what else to do, Ben called a local loan company that advertised immediate second mortgage loans for homeowners.

"Ben, I absolutely will not sign to get a second mortgage on this house," Naomi stated. "We can't pay the bills we have now!"